

When Ferber Fails: The Sleep Training Survival Guide for Exhausted Parents — Action Checklist

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MEDICAL EVALUATION

- ☐ **Medical Evaluation:** Ask your pediatrician about reflux if your baby arches their back, grunts frequently, or seems uncomfortable after feeds, since crying may signal pain rather than protest during sleep training attempts.
- ☐ **Sensitivity Screening:** Request testing for cow's milk protein allergy if you notice blood or mucus in stool, severe diaper rash, or eczema, since gut inflammation from food sensitivities worsens at night.
- ☐ **Medical Consultation:** Speak specifically with your doctor about reflux and CMPA rather than assuming sleep training failure, since a 2–3 week trial of specialized formula or dietary changes can reveal the real cause.
- ☐ **Dietary Trial:** Implement a dairy-free diet if breastfeeding or switch to Alimentum or Nutramigen formula for 2–3 weeks to determine whether food sensitivities are driving the sleep disruptions.

DEVELOPMENTAL & HUNGER FACTORS

- ☐ **Leap Calendar Check:** Download the Wonder Weeks app or visit Leaping.com to identify if your baby is in an active developmental leap, since sleep training during a leap is ineffective for 2–3 weeks.
- ☐ **Growth Spurt Recognition:** Watch for sudden increases in feeding frequency, cluster feeding in the evening, and a contented baby suddenly becoming fussy, since these indicate a growth spurt that pauses sleep training.
- ☐ **Demand Feeding:** Feed on demand during growth spurts without attempting sleep training, since a hungry baby cannot be trained to ignore a biological signal and this approach is both ineffective and cruel.
- ☐ **Wake Window Adjustment:** Extend wake windows by 30 minutes if your baby resists sleep training, since overtiredness causes cortisol production that makes self-soothing progressively harder.

SLEEP TRAINING ADJUSTMENTS

- ☐ **Sleepy Cue Monitoring:** Watch for eye rubbing, zoning out, and decreased activity rather than watching the clock, since a baby who is genuinely ready to sleep learns self-soothing much faster.
 - ☐ **Chair Method Start:** Begin the Chair Method by sitting in a chair right beside your baby's crib for the first 2–3 nights, touching the crib rail and murmuring reassuringly without picking up your baby.
 - ☐ **Chair Method Progression:** Move the chair slightly further away each night, from beside the crib to the doorway by night 5–7, allowing your baby to gradually adjust to falling asleep without immediate parental presence.
 - ☐ **Early Nap Timing:** Move your baby's first nap earlier in the day to prevent overtiredness from building up, since overtiredness is the number one reason sleep training fails and makes self-soothing nearly impossible.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.